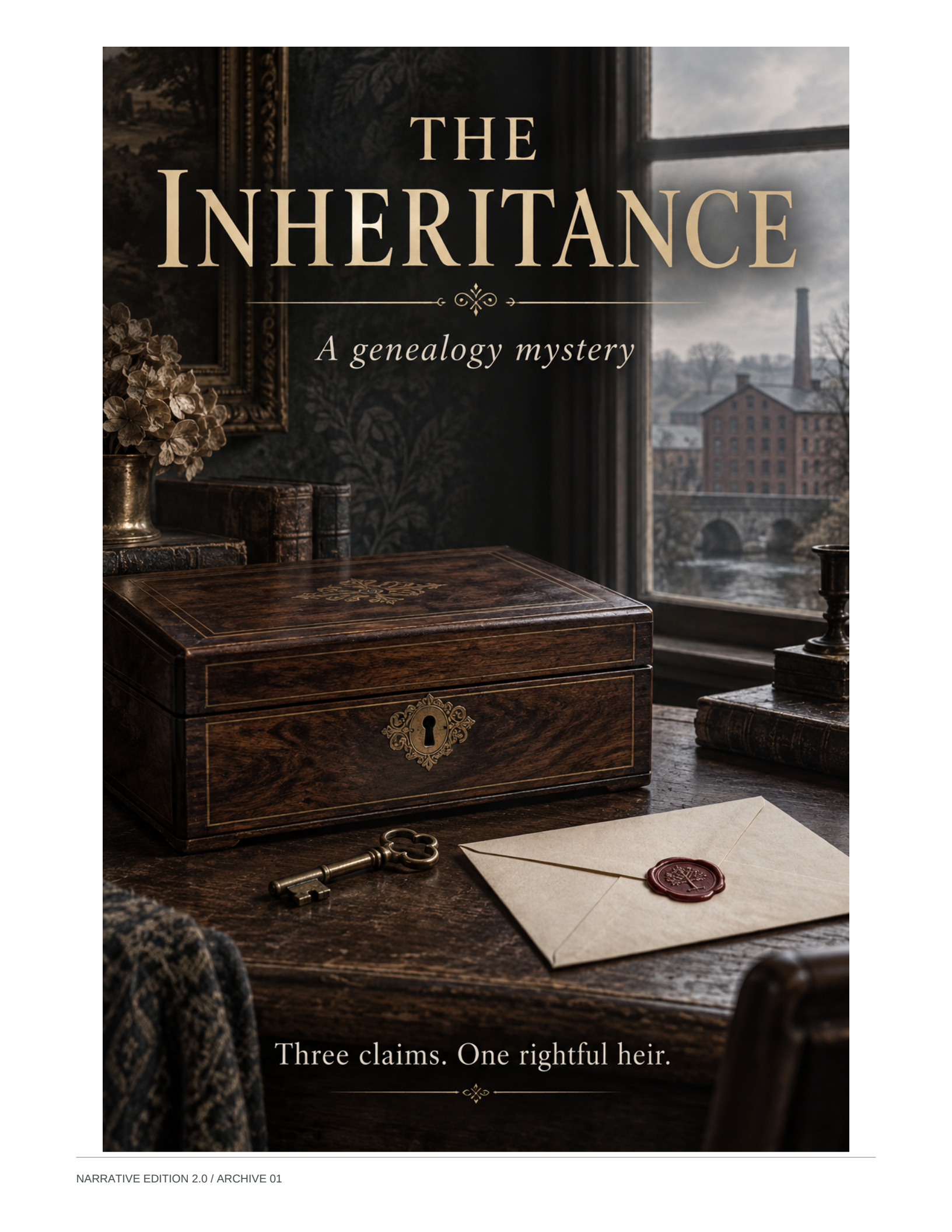




THE INHERITANCE

A genealogy mystery

Three claims. One rightful heir.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The keys on Ruth's desk

Before the opening brief

Ruth Fenwick put the mill keys on a folded cloth. She had discovered that leaving them in sight made people speak to the keys instead of to her. Putting them away made people ask where they were. There seemed to be no neutral place for an inheritance.

Nell Mercer arrived with papers she had tried to keep flat. Arthur's papers were already arranged. Clara Whitcomb paused at the doorway until Ruth moved a chair out for her.

"We could have settled the family part ourselves," Arthur said.

Nell sat down. "Then you wouldn't have needed my papers."

He gave her the weary look of a brother being contradicted in company. Ruth saw Nell almost answer it with an apology. Instead she put her packet on the desk.

Clara kept her hands in her lap. She was the person easiest for the others to treat as an intrusion. Ruth asked her to move closer so she could see the will.

"I didn't choose my mother's name to inconvenience anyone," Clara said quietly.

Arthur looked embarrassed. Nell made room on the desk.

Henry Vale had left words that seemed simple until living people began placing themselves inside them. Earliest-born. Surviving. Child. The claimants could all tell stories about what a family ought to recognize. The document required a particular relationship and an order of birth.

"I am not asking which of you needs the property most," Ruth said. "Nor which of you can speak most confidently about it."

"It has to be managed," Arthur said.

"That is a different question."

Nell looked at the keys. She had not been offered the ease of treating the business as a foregone conclusion. Even being asked what she intended to do with it would have meant somebody believed she might have a claim.

Ruth turned the will so everyone could read. "You may dislike the result. I won't ask you to dislike it less. I will ask you to let the papers be checked."

Outside, the town's work went on. Inside, three people waited for an old man's language to determine which of their futures could become real. Ruth kept her hand beside the keys. Not on them. Nobody had yet earned an answer merely by reaching first.

The executor needs a name.

Bellwether, Pennsylvania / 21 October 1912

Henry Vale is dead. The mill still runs, but the keys to his house remain on the executor's desk. His will names a relationship instead of a person: his sister's eldest surviving child.

Three people have come forward. One has the earliest birth date. One carries the family surname. One uses a name that does not appear in the baptism register. The records cannot all mean what the claimants think they mean.

Your commission: identify the person entitled to the estate under E01. Reconstruct the necessary family relationships, test the three claims, and submit an evidence-cited conclusion on page 21.

Start with E01 and E02. Then choose your own route through the archive catalog. Each time you find a discrepancy, write a question and look for the record that could answer it. The exhibit order is a catalog, not a required reading order.

Case boundaries: all possible living beneficiaries for this fictional case are among C1-C3. There are no hidden claimants, missing decisive documents, legal traps or coded messages. This is a rule of the investigation, not a claim that a small archive proves a family complete.

Finish when: you can name the heir, explain each competing claim, resolve the household and burial contradictions, and identify what the documents cannot prove. Then open the separate sealed solution.

All people, places, institutions and case documents are fictional. Evidence pages are readable typeset facsimiles or selected-field transcriptions, not authentic archival scans. Census field choices follow historical formats; the bequest operates under the rules printed here.

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Archive catalog

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READ FIRST

Read the people. Test the papers.

Print the Player PDF in full. This edition contains 25 pages, including its cover and interleaved story. Use US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%; on A4, use Fit. Grayscale is sufficient. Single-sided lets you spread the records out; duplex uses the long edge. Keep the separate hints and sealed solution away from the player stack.

Follow the printed archive folios. Existing page references mean the numbers labeled ARCHIVE in the footers, which remain stable. New story leaves use S0-S3. They make the PDF positions different from the archive numbers. Use the bookmarks or clickable catalog to find a page on screen.

Begin with the opening scene and brief. Read E01-E02 and choose your next record through archive folio 3. Each later scene names the records to read first. In a nonlinear search, return to that scene after you have examined its records; scene order does not prove a connection.

Let the records carry the proof. The new scenes dramatize the people around these papers. They are fictional narrative, not additional archival exhibits. A character can be mistaken. Names, dates, parents, addresses, source references, and the supplied rules establish the case; sympathy does not.

Make your case. Use archive folios 19-21. Cite exhibit codes and exact fields, test alternatives, and leave unsupported matters open. Everyone investigates; no host, internet, cutting, or outside research is required. Use hints only when needed; open the solution after answering all final questions.

C1-C3 are the complete possible living beneficiaries in this fictional case. Apply the bequest printed in E01.

The disputed bequest

Will extract / 17 June 1908

Vale estate papers / instrument 18 / clause IV

I, Henry Vale, of Bellwether, Pennsylvania, direct that my house, my interest in Vale Mill, and the remainder of my estate pass to the eldest child born to my sister Ada who shall be living at my death.

By my sister Ada I mean Ada Vale, daughter of Martin Vale and Eliza Vale, who married Joseph Reed of Bellwether. By eldest I mean earliest born; a deceased child shall be passed over. Neither sex nor present surname shall give preference.

My executor shall establish that person from the family records before releasing the estate. I have been long absent from my sister's household and will not risk an erroneous name in this instrument.

Testator	Henry Vale
Witnesses	Martha Stone; Peter Voss
Death recorded by executor	1 October 1912
Estate file	HV / 1912 / 18

Game rule: apply the clause exactly as written. Its validity is stipulated. No knowledge of inheritance law is needed.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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Three claims on the estate

Executor's interview register / 14 October 1912

Vale estate papers / claims C1-C3

Each claimant appeared in person today. These are their statements, entered before the records were compared. A recorded claim is not a finding of fact.

C1 / Clara Whitcomb / 6 Market Street, Greybank

"I was Clara Reed before my marriage. I was born on 3 March 1867, and my mother was Ada Reed. My baptismal entry is enclosed. If the eldest child inherits, my date should settle it."

C2 / Arthur Reed / 8 Foundry Lane, Bellwether

"I was born on 6 February 1872 to Joseph and Ada Reed. My father spoke of a sister called Ellen who was buried as a child. The cemetery index has an Ellen Reed in our family plot. I believe I am the surviving child intended."

C3 / Nell Mercer / 83 Ferry Street, Bellwether

"Joseph Reed was my father. People have called me Nell for as long as I remember. I was born in September 1870. I married Edward Mercer at St Jude's. My family papers did not come to me when Father died."

Recorded by Ruth Fenwick, executor. Claims taken without deciding the accuracy of any asserted relationship. All three claimants are alive on this date.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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A household on Mill Street

1900 census extract / Reference date: 1 June 1900

Selected population fields / Bellwether / dwelling 91 / family 94

Address	20 Mill Street, Bellwether, Pennsylvania
Household head	Joseph Reed

Name	Relation to head	Birth	Age	Status
Reed, Joseph	Head	Jan 1843	57	M
Reed, Rachel	Wife	Oct 1848	51	M
Mercer, Edward	Son-in-law	Apr 1868	32	M
Mercer, Nell	Daughter	Sep 1870	29	M

Name	Years married	Children born	Children living
Rachel Reed	22	0	0
Nell Mercer	6	1	1

Additional line: Mercer, Alice / granddaughter / Feb 1896 / age 4 / S.

Selected-field transcription. Relationships in the schedule are to the household head. Childbearing columns record the woman's reported births. They do not identify the mother of every child in the household.

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The claimants in 1910

Three census extracts / Reference date: 15 April 1910

Selected population fields / Bellwether and Greybank

Bellwether / 83 Ferry Street / family 41

Name	Relation	Age	Occupation
Mercer, Edward	Head	42	Compositor
Mercer, Nell	Wife	39	None entered
Mercer, Alice	Daughter	14	None entered

Bellwether / 8 Foundry Lane / family 17

Name	Relation	Age	Occupation
Reed, Arthur J.	Head	38	Pattern maker
Reed, Florence	Wife	35	None entered

Greybank / 6 Market Street / family 63

Name	Relation	Age	Occupation
Whitcomb, Walter	Head	46	Grocer
Whitcomb, Clara	Wife	43	None entered

Separate households, brought together for comparison. Ages are completed years on the reference date; they are not exact dates of birth. Address continuity can support identification but does not establish parentage.

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THE STORY CONTINUES

A place in somebody else's house

After E03-E04

Nell followed the household names with her finger, stopping before it touched the ink. It was an odd experience to see a home flattened into a list. There was a head of household, then everyone else arranged by relationship to that head.

"People hear daughter and think they know the mother," she said.

Ruth let the observation stand without turning it into a conclusion. The schedule would have to be read alongside other records. Family familiarity could make a mistaken reading feel obvious.

Arthur drew his chair toward the desk. "Nobody is denying you were part of the family."

Nell looked at him. "That isn't the only question you've been answering for me."

He opened his mouth, then reached for his own claim instead. Ruth wondered whether he heard the difference between letting a sister belong and letting her have a claim that could defeat his. She could not certify what he understood. She could require him to support what he said.

Clara asked which Ada the will meant. For the first time, both siblings turned toward her as a person who had asked a useful question.

"The one it identifies," Ruth said, bringing the will nearer. "We must connect the entries."

Clara nodded. "Then connect mine too. Even if they lead away."

Nell looked at her and moved the census so Clara could see the whole page. It was a small alliance, not a promise to agree. They were both asking for their records to receive the same attention as Arthur's confidence.

The later addresses made the family harder to imagine as one familiar room. People married, worked, moved, and appeared under names that would make sense in one record and obscure them in another. A daughter could leave a house without leaving her ancestry. A shared surname could invite recognition the parents' names did not sustain.

Ruth set a clean comparison sheet between the claimants. "Write down what would prove your claim," she said. "And what would disprove it."

Nobody reached for the pencil immediately.

St Jude's baptism register

Parish register extract / Entries: 1868-1872

St Jude's, Bellwether / book B / selected entries

Entry	Child	Born	Baptized
B-41	Lucy Ellen Reed	4 May 1868	31 May 1868
B-73	Ellen May Reed	12 Sep 1870	9 Oct 1870
B-81	George Pell	3 Jan 1871	29 Jan 1871
B-92	Arthur Joseph Reed	6 Feb 1872	3 Mar 1872

Parent and residence columns

B-41	Joseph Reed; Ada Reed, formerly Vale / 20 Mill Street
B-73	Joseph Reed; Ada Reed, formerly Vale / 20 Mill Street
B-81	Robert Pell; Mary Pell, formerly Shaw / 9 Ferry Street
B-92	Joseph Reed; Ada Reed, formerly Vale / 20 Mill Street

Dates of birth and baptism occupy different columns. This selection contains relevant entries and one neighboring entry; it is not a claim that the register contains every birth in the town.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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A name in the burial index

Cemetery index leaf / Index copied: 12 October 1912

St Jude's burial ground / surname index / R

Indexed name	Buried	Plot	Ledger reference
Reed, Ada	19 Aug 1876	B17	III / 64
Reed, Joseph	5 Feb 1906	B17	VI / 28
Reed, L. Ellen	22 Nov 1868	B17	II / 19
Reed, Peter	8 Jan 1882	C06	IV / 7

Index entries are abbreviated. Consult the sexton's ledger for full names, age at death and the person responsible for burial.

Leaf	R / 12
Copied by	A. Pike, cemetery clerk
Finding aid	The estate archive includes the requested ledger extract under its own catalog entry.

The index was compiled from burial books. It is a finding aid derived from those books, not an independent witness to a death.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

A marriage at St Jude's

Parish marriage register / 14 May 1866

St Jude's, Bellwether / marriages / entry M-28

Groom	Joseph Reed
Age; occupation	23; joiner
Bride	Ada Vale
Age; residence	21; Bellwether
Bride's parents	Martin Vale and Eliza Vale
Witnesses	Henry Vale and Martha Stone
Marriage date	14 May 1866
Minister	Rev. Daniel Price

The parties were married at St Jude's in the presence of the witnesses above. Entry made on the day of the ceremony.

An invented parish record with a simplified readable layout. It establishes the identities claimed by the marriage record; compare it with other records.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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A baptism in Greybank

Parish baptism register / Baptism: 24 March 1867

Trinity Chapel, Greybank / book 2 / entry 116

Child	Clara Reed
Date of birth	3 March 1867
Date of baptism	24 March 1867
Father	Samuel Reed
Mother	Ada Reed
Father's occupation	Baker
Residence	4 Orchard Row, Greybank
Minister	Rev. Elias Holt

Copy requested by Mrs Clara Whitcomb on 10 October 1912. Copied from the birth and baptism columns; the mother's maiden surname is not entered in this record.

This is the baptismal entry referred to in C1. A missing maiden surname should remain unknown until another record supplies it.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

The cost of an easy name

After E05-E08

The burial index was the shortest paper on the desk. That made it tempting. The claimants had been reading dates and parents for long enough to want one line that settled something.

Arthur tapped the abbreviation, then stopped when Ruth looked at his hand.

"It's what I understood," he said.

"I have written that down as your understanding."

"You make it sound as if I invented it."

"No. I am asking what supports it."

Nell had spent much of the morning wanting Ruth to speak more sharply to him. Now she was relieved that she had not. A quarrel would let everyone remember the insult instead of the record. Whatever this entry meant, it belonged to a child, not merely to a claim that needed removing.

Clara looked from the baptismal names to her own parents' entry. "My mother was called Ada," she said. This time she did not offer it as an answer. It was a fact she had carried all her life, suddenly too small for the work she wanted it to do.

Nell understood the humiliation of having something intimate treated as insufficient. She also understood, unwillingly, that being hurt by the request did not make the request wrong.

Ruth placed the abbreviated burial entry beside its source reference. "An index helps us find a record. We still need the record."

Arthur leaned back. The full extract would take his explanation out of the territory of things the family had always said. It might confirm him. It might not. Ruth offered no prediction.

The marriage and baptismal entries had once served people who needed a union entered, a child named, a burial recorded. They had not been written to referee this room. Their indifference to the claimants' wishes was what made them useful.

Nell read the child's name again, this time in full. She did not yet write a conclusion beside it. She wanted the keys. She wanted, unexpectedly, not to become someone who could hurry a dead child out of the way merely because the page promised an advantage.

A wedding on Ferry Street

Parish marriage register / 20 June 1894

St Jude's, Bellwether / marriages / entry M-203

Groom	Edward Mercer
Groom's age; occupation	26; compositor
Bride	Ellen May Reed
Bride's age; residence	23; 20 Mill Street, Bellwether
Bride's father	Joseph Reed, joiner
Bride's mother	Ada Reed, formerly Vale; deceased
Witnesses	Arthur Joseph Reed and Rachel Reed
Address after marriage	83 Ferry Street, Bellwether

Ceremony performed at St Jude's. The couple gave 83 Ferry Street as their intended residence. Their subsequent residence is not certified by this entry.

Later addresses may differ. People can move away and return; an intended address is not proof of uninterrupted residence.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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The Whitcomb marriage

Parish marriage register / 18 October 1888

Trinity Chapel, Greybank / marriages / entry 88

Groom	Walter Whitcomb
Groom's age; occupation	24; grocer
Bride	Clara Reed
Bride's age; residence	21; 4 Orchard Row, Greybank
Bride's father	Samuel Reed, baker
Bride's mother	Ada Reed, formerly Marsh
Witnesses	Samuel Reed and Agnes Marsh
Marriage date	18 October 1888

The bride and groom signed in the presence of the witnesses. The parents' names and former surname were entered at the time of the ceremony.

Compare parent names, residence and occupation across records. A repeated given name does not by itself identify the same person.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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The sexton's ledger

Burial ledger extract / 22 November 1868

St Jude's burial ground / volume II / folio 19

Name of deceased	Lucy Ellen Reed
Date of death	20 November 1868
Age at death	6 months, 16 days
Date of burial	22 November 1868
Father and mother	Joseph Reed and Ada Reed
Residence	20 Mill Street, Bellwether
Plot	B17
Burial ordered by	Joseph Reed
Ledger reference	II / 19

Infant interment. Sexton: Alfred Pike. Plot charge entered in the account of Joseph Reed.

A full ledger entry supplies fields the surname index omits. The shared ledger reference ties the index to this record.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

Joseph Reed marries again

Parish marriage register / 9 February 1878

St Jude's, Bellwether / marriages / entry M-97

Groom	Joseph Reed
Age; occupation	35; joiner
Condition	Widower of Ada Reed, formerly Vale
Late wife's death	16 August 1876
Bride	Rachel Dunn
Age; condition	29; unmarried
Residence after marriage	20 Mill Street, Bellwether
Witnesses	Peter Voss and Martha Stone
Marriage date	9 February 1878

Bride and groom signed before Rev. Daniel Price. Details of the prior marriage were supplied for this entry.

This record names the partners in a later marriage. It does not change the parentage recorded in earlier births.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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A school admission

School register extract / 3 September 1877

Mill Street School / admissions / entry 246

Pupil entered as	Ellen May Reed
Name used in class	Nell Reed
Date of birth supplied	12 September 1870
Parent or guardian	Joseph Reed, joiner
Home address	20 Mill Street, Bellwether
Previous school	None entered
Date admitted	3 September 1877
Teacher	Miss Marion Cole

Marginal note, in the admission hand: "Answers to Nell. Use full name in the register."

The admission predates the estate dispute. Compare its identity fields with the baptism, marriage and household records.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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A death notice

Newspaper extract / 18 August 1876

The Bellwether Weekly / family notices / page 3

DEATHS / REED

At 20 Mill Street, on the 16th inst., Ada, wife of Joseph Reed and daughter of Martin and Eliza Vale, in her thirty-second year.

Mrs Reed leaves her husband, her daughter Ellen and her son Arthur. Her brother, Mr Henry Vale, has returned from Pittsburgh for the burial. Friends will assemble at St Jude's on Saturday, the 19th, at two o'clock.

No flowers are requested. Contributions to the school book fund may be left with the minister.

"The 16th inst." means the 16th of the current month. "In her thirty-second year" means she had completed 31 years. A notice can corroborate family claims without being an exhaustive birth history.

Research note / What does this change? Which record would test it?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

What a brother could offer

After E09-E14

Arthur tried to make the conversation private by lowering his voice. Ruth could still hear every word.

"Whatever happens, I wouldn't leave you without help," he told Nell.

She stared at him. The offer might have been sincere. Its sincerity was part of what angered her.

"You keep making a place for me after you've put yourself first."

"I'm trying to say we needn't fall out."

"Then let the order be checked without asking me to thank you."

Clara looked away, giving them the privacy the room could not. Ruth left the certificates where they lay. A sister's anger did not establish her birth order; a brother's generosity did not establish his. Neither feeling had to be false for the evidence to contradict a claim.

The fuller records required a slower comparison: names before marriage, named parents, exact dates, an age at burial, a school entry made for the practical business of knowing which child answered when called. Ordinary details survived where confident family shorthand had become unreliable.

Clara asked for her marriage extract back. "May I copy the reference?"

"Of course," Ruth said.

She wrote carefully. It was the first thing she had done all morning that was not directed at acquiring the property. Whatever the final answer, she would take away a properly identified record of her own family. Nell watched her and felt some of the room's urgency loosen. Losing a claim did not make a life a distraction.

Arthur had gone quiet. Nell could not tell whether he was reconsidering the documents or simply finding a more defensible way to remain certain. She would have to let his next action answer that.

Ruth drew the keys toward the center of the desk.

"Now," she said, "set out the line from the woman named in the will. Give me each connection. Give me the order. And show me which child the burial actually records."

Nell took up the pencil. For once she was being asked to make her case in full, rather than fit herself into a future somebody else had already described.

Compare the three claims.

Write facts with exhibit IDs. Keep a claim separate from what you can substantiate.

C1 / Clara Whitcomb

Birth identity and date / Parents / Connection to the named Ada / Evidence

C2 / Arthur Reed

Birth identity and date / Parents / Connection to the named Ada / Evidence

C3 / Nell Mercer

Birth identity and date / Parents / Connection to the named Ada / Evidence

My current hypothesis and the strongest evidence against it:

[Return to archive catalog](#)

Rebuild the family.

Place names in these spaces only when a record supports the link. Mark biological parent, spouse and step-parent distinctly. Write the exhibit next to each connection.

The Ada named in the will: parents, spouse and dates

Children of that Ada: full names, birth dates and survival evidence

Other marriages and household relationships

Names that refer to one person / Names that refer to different people

[Return to archive catalog](#)

Who receives the keys?

Summarize here; use your worksheets for the supporting detail.

1. Name the heir, the birth name, and the exact birth date.

2. Trace the heir to Henry Vale's sister using at least three exhibits.

3. Explain why each of the other two claims does not win.

4. Identify the person behind the burial index entry. Resolve the 1900 household contradiction.

5. Can you prove that a claimant knowingly lied? State what remains uncertain.

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